

THREAT INTELLIGENCE ASSESSMENT

LockBit Ransomware Group

Operation Cronos and the aftermath — RaaS collapse, affiliate fallout, and the return of a diminished monopoly.

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Severity: high



Ransomware · RaaS



Dark web sourced

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — PREVIEW

LockBit built the most commercially successful ransomware-as-a-service operation on record — 2,000+ claimed victims across 120 countries on a 20% cut. In February 2024, Operation Cronos seized its infrastructure, source code and 7,000+ decryption keys, and unmasked its administrator. The group was back online in five days, but the trust that underpinned its affiliate network was not.

DATE OF ASSESSMENT

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REPORT VERSION

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ANALYST

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CLASSIFICATION

TLP:WHITE

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HANDLING AND CONFIDENCE

This assessment is marked TLP:WHITE and may be shared without restriction. Judgements are expressed with explicit confidence levels — high, moderate or low — reflecting source reliability and corroboration. All findings derive from open-source reporting, law enforcement disclosures and dark web forum collection; no client telemetry is included.

SECTION 01

Executive summary

Threat actor profile, dark web intelligence, and the law enforcement action that broke the market's largest RaaS brand.

2,000+

Claimed victims since 2019

120

Countries affected

\$91M

Ransom paid by US victims (FBI)

LockBit is one of the most prolific and financially damaging ransomware groups in history, operating a highly commercialised **ransomware-as-a-service (RaaS)** model that enabled widespread global attacks through a network of criminal affiliates. First emerging in 2019 as “ABCD” ransomware before rebranding to LockBit in 2020, the group claimed over 2,000 victims across 120 countries, targeting healthcare, government, finance and education.

Unlike politically motivated actors, LockBit operated as a purely financially driven criminal enterprise, deploying **triple extortion** — encrypting victim data, threatening public release of stolen files, and launching DDoS attacks to maximise payment pressure.

OPERATION CRONOS — FEBRUARY 2024

A coordinated international operation led by the UK National Crime Agency and involving 13 countries disrupted LockBit's infrastructure, seized their leak sites and arrested key members. LockBit resurfaced five days later with a new leak site, claiming to hold data belonging to high-profile victims including the FBI, and threatening to release court documents involving former US President Donald Trump.

LockBit continues to represent a significant threat due to evolving malware capabilities, a decentralised affiliate network, and demonstrated operational resilience in the face of law enforcement action. Activity data through mid-2026 shows 270+ claimed victims for the year and a fourth-place ranking among globally tracked ransomware operations — materially diminished from its former monopoly, but far from dormant.



Bottom line — takedowns degrade capability; they do not remove it. While the core developers remain at large, LockBit persists.

SECTION 02

Intelligence dashboard

Consolidated view of scale, targeting and current operational tempo.



SECTION 03

Key judgements

Analytic conclusions with stated confidence.

KJ-1 LockBit retains meaningful operational capability **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

160+ claims in Q1 2026 — more than double the prior quarter — a 500% month-over-month rebound in June 2026, and 270+ victims by mid-year confirm continued payload development and active affiliate recruitment.

KJ-2 The RaaS monopoly is permanently broken **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

The unmasking of LockBitSupp, forum bans on XSS.in and Exploit.in, and the disclosure that the administrator sought to negotiate with the FBI destroyed the reputational capital that attracted affiliates. Recovery to a market-leading position is unlikely.

KJ-3 Disruption displaced risk rather than reducing it **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

RansomHub, Qilin and Akira absorbed displaced affiliates and expanded rapidly. Aggregate double-extortion volume across the ecosystem did not fall; the operators simply changed brand.

KJ-4 Version 5.0 prioritises stealth over speed **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Cross-platform Windows, Linux and ESXi support plus a quiet mode for silent background encryption trade encryption throughput for dwell time — shifting detection weight from performance anomalies to behavioural telemetry.

KJ-5 Threat persists while core developers remain at large **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Infrastructure seizure without arrest of technical leadership permits reconstitution. Dmitry Khoroshev remains at liberty despite indictment, sanctions and a \$10 million reward.

💡 INTELLIGENCE GAP

Current affiliate headcount and the geographic distribution of LockBit 5.0 operators are not observable from leak-site data alone. Claim counts are self-reported and historically inflated with recycled victim data.

SECTION 04

Group background and evolution

From ABCD ransomware to the most sophisticated RaaS operation on record.

LockBit first emerged in 2019 under the name ABCD ransomware before rebranding and evolving into one of the most sophisticated ransomware operations ever recorded. The group progressed through three major iterations before Operation Cronos, and two more after it.

OPERATIONAL TIMELINE

- **2019 Emergence as “ABCD” ransomware**
First observed in the wild; rebranded to LockBit in 2020.
- **1.0 Foundational encryption capability**
Established the core encryption routine and affiliate onboarding model.
- **2.0 StealBit and double extortion at scale**
Custom-built exfiltration tool accelerated double extortion and specifically targeted Active Directory environments.
- **3.0 LockBit Black — most advanced and evasive variant**
Modular architecture, stronger encryption, target-specific payload customisation. Borrowed techniques from BlackCat and BlackMatter. First ransomware operation to run a bug bounty programme.
- **FEB 2024 Operation Cronos**
Infrastructure seized. Relaunch five days later; LockBit-NG-Dev, then 4.0 and 5.0 follow.



Corporate mindset

Professional business practices and a highly automated attack platform that lowered the technical barrier for affiliates.



Bug bounty programme

Unprecedented in the criminal underground — paid researchers to find flaws in LockBit's own infrastructure.



Deliberate brand building

LockBitSupp was vocal on dark web forums, mocking rivals who operated in the shadows to attract high-quality affiliates.



Unprecedented scale

2,000+ victims across 120+ countries; manufacturing and industrial infrastructure hit hardest.

SECTION 05

The RaaS model and its economics

A strict division of labour, and the most affiliate-friendly split in the market.

<> Core development team

- Malware source code
- Payment gateway infrastructure
- Dark web leak sites and negotiation portals

👤 Recruited affiliates

- Initial access to victim networks
- Lateral movement and privilege escalation
- Payload deployment and ransom collection

RANSOM SPLIT

80% affiliate

20% core

Affiliates collected payments directly from victims; LockBit took a 20% cut — one of the most affiliate-friendly splits in the RaaS market, and a direct driver of their growth.

\$777

Upfront infrastructure fee for affiliate panel access

\$1K – \$10M+

Ransom demand range by target size

\$80M

Highest confirmed demand — Royal Mail UK

TRIPLE EXTORTION CHAIN

🔒

Encrypt

Halt operations by encrypting production data

→

📁

Leak

Threaten public release of exfiltrated files

→

🔌

Disrupt

DDoS public services to compound pressure

SECTION 06

Dark web chatter and forum activity

Collection from Russian-language cybercriminal forums following Operation Cronos.

**LockBitSupp**

Administrator · damage control narrative

ASSESSED DECEPTIVE

Claimed all primary servers had been taken offline safely and that law enforcement had only compromised a single unpatched PHP server. Insisted the impact was minimal and operations would resume quickly — an attempt to maintain affiliate confidence.

The affiliate community reacted with immediate panic and distrust. Affiliates came to realise LockBit had misrepresented its security protocols and — critically — that LockBitSupp had attempted to negotiate with the FBI to protect his own identity, a fundamental betrayal of trust within the criminal ecosystem.

dealfixer

Initial access broker

Advertised network access publicly while stating they no longer wished to work with LockBit.

n30n

Access broker · ramp_v2 forum

Opened a formal claim citing payments lost as a direct result of the disruption.

FORUM SENTIMENT — XSS.IN AND EXPLOIT.IN

Intense frustration

Paranoia

Open schadenfreude

LockBitSupp banned

“script kiddies running an enterprise”

Forum members on LockBit's failure to patch a basic server vulnerability

“ghost town”

On the rebuilt leak site, accused of recycling old victim data to simulate activity

**REPUTATIONAL INVERSION**

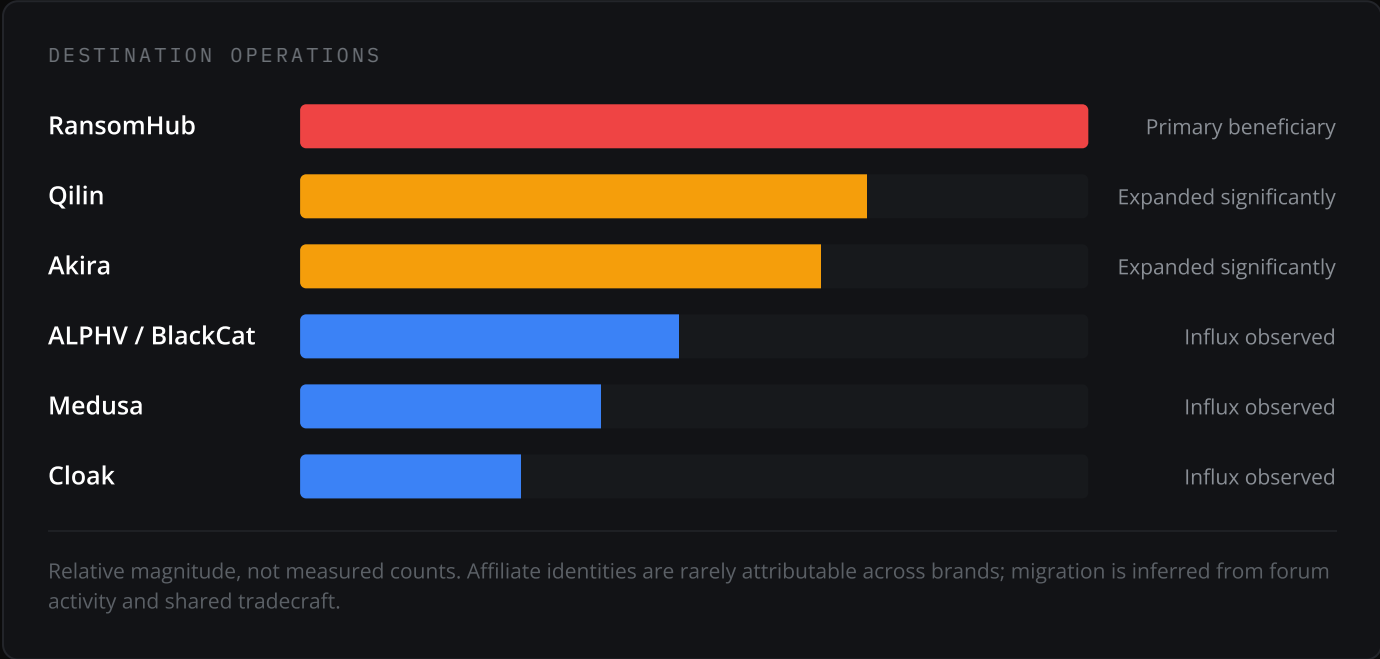
Forum members openly conceded that the FBI had out-trolled the gang — repurposing LockBit's own leak site to post gang member information, turning the group's signature weapon against it.

SECTION 07

Affiliate fallout and migration

Where LockBit's operators went when confidence collapsed.

The fallout accelerated affiliate migration to rival ransomware operations. Groups including ALPHV (BlackCat), RansomHub, Akira, Medusa and Cloak all saw an influx of former LockBit affiliates seeking more stable and trustworthy RaaS platforms.



TRIGGER

Misrepresented security protocols; single unpatched server exposed the whole estate.

ACCELERANT

Administrator sought to negotiate with the FBI, exposing affiliates to protect himself.

RESULT

Forum bans, reputational collapse, and permanent loss of preferred-platform status.

DEFENDER IMPLICATION

Detections tuned to the LockBit brand miss the same operators working under RansomHub, Qilin or Akira. Prioritise affiliate tradecraft — initial access vectors, StealBit-style exfiltration, Active Directory abuse — over family-specific signatures.

SECTION 08

Victim analysis

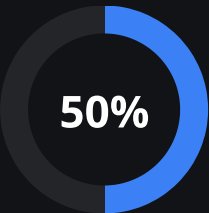
A targeting strategy built on organisations least able to absorb downtime.

MOST TARGETED SECTORS



Only the manufacturing figure is a confirmed count; remaining bars show relative ranking from claimed-victim analysis.

US SHARE OF ATTACKS



Approximately half of all known LockBit attacks impacted US-based entities.

GEOGRAPHIC CONCENTRATION

United States	1,700 incidents · \$91M paid
Canada	22% of national ransomware
Australia	18% of national ransomware
United Kingdom	240 victims contacted by NCA

A consistent pattern of targeting English-speaking, high-income nations with mature digital infrastructure.

TARGETING RATIONALE

The logic was straightforward and ruthlessly effective: select organisations that cannot afford operational downtime, then combine stolen sensitive corporate data with encryption to create dual pressure. A tiered pricing strategy — from \$1,000 against small targets to tens of millions against large corporations — extracted maximum value from every victim regardless of size.

SECTION 09

Notable victims

Publicly reported incidents attributed to LockBit or its affiliates.

Organisation	Sector	Demand (USD)	Reported outcome
Royal Mail UK	Logistics	\$80M	Highest confirmed demand recorded against any LockBit victim
CDW	Technology distribution	\$80M	Among the largest demands ever recorded
TSMC	Semiconductors	\$70M	Breach of third-party supplier Kinmax Technology
Boeing	Aerospace	Not disclosed	Refused to pay; data stolen and published to the leak site
UK Ministry of Defence	Government	Not disclosed	Significant breach exposing sensitive government data
Accenture	IT services	Not disclosed	High-profile target; listed on LockBit infrastructure

THIRD-PARTY EXPOSURE

The TSMC case is instructive: the world's largest semiconductor manufacturer was extorted through a supplier breach, not a compromise of its own estate. Supplier risk is ransomware risk.

NON-PAYMENT OUTCOME

Boeing refused to pay and absorbed publication. Where recovery is viable and data sensitivity is manageable, refusal remains a defensible position.

Demand figures are as reported publicly and, where sourced from leak-site claims, are self-reported by the group. Absence of a figure does not imply no demand was made.

SECTION 10

Operation Cronos

19 February 2024 — the most significant law enforcement action ever taken against a ransomware group.

THREE-PHASE APPROACH

PHASE 01

Infiltrate

Penetrate systems and extract intelligence, source code and internal data

PHASE 02

Seize

Take administrative control of the primary administration environment

PHASE 03

Lock out

Exclude the group from its own infrastructure entirely

34

Servers seized

11,000+

Rogue domains disrupted

7,000+

Decryption keys recovered

240

UK victims contacted by NCA

COALITION — TEN COUNTRIES

UK National Crime Agency · South West ROCU
AU Australian Federal Police
JP National Police Agency
CH Federal Office of Police
DE Bundeskriminalamt and state police bodies

US Department of Justice · FBI Newark field office
CA Royal Canadian Mounted Police
SE National Police Authority
FR Gendarmerie Nationale — C3N
NL National Police cybercrime teams

Coordinated at European level by Europol and Eurojust.



PSYCHOLOGICAL OPERATION

Authorities repurposed LockBit's own leak site to display law enforcement splash pages and administrator reveals. The group's signature countdown timers — previously used to pressure victims — were redirected to count down to arrest announcements and source code reveals.

SECTION 11

Attribution and enforcement outcomes

Arrests, indictments and the unmasking of LockBitSupp.

PRIMARY ADMINISTRATOR – INDICTED

Dmitry Yuryevich Khoroshev
alias “LockBitSupp”

DOJ indictment · May 2024

Sanctions and asset freezes

At large

US REWARD

\$10M

For information leading to his capture

Jurisdiction	Action	Detail
United Kingdom	Arrests	Suspected developer and supporting affiliates detained
Spain	Arrest	Hosting provider apprehended
United States	Indictment and sanctions	Khoroshev unmasked and charged; assets frozen

 **What worked**

- Source code and internal data seized intact
- Victims recovered without paying
- Brand trust destroyed within the criminal market

 **What did not**

- Core developers remained at liberty
- Relaunch achieved in five days
- Displaced affiliates strengthened rival operations

Lesson — infrastructure disruption alone is insufficient without addressing the core developers. While LockBitSupp and the group's technical leadership remain at large, the threat will persist.

SECTION 12

Current status and outlook

Reconstitution, version 5.0, and a diminished but persistent threat.

LockBit relaunched on 24 February 2024 — five days after Cronos — publishing new victims on a rebuilt leak site and shifting to decentralised infrastructure across multiple separate servers to reduce single-point takedown risk. Rather than rebuilding from the compromised 3.0 codebase, the group developed the interim **LockBit-NG-Dev** variant before deploying 4.0 and, subsequently, 5.0.

4.0 December 2024

- Cross-platform: Windows, Linux, ESXi
- Stealthier defence evasion; simplified packaging
- Command line support and open victim chat
- Quiet mode — silent background encryption
- Slower encryption than 3.0 — a stealth tradeoff

5.0 2025 — “ChuongDong”

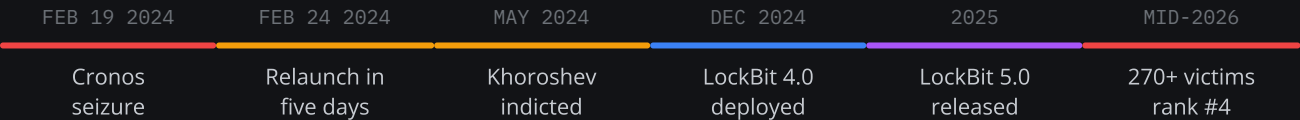
The current generation, driving the 2026 resurgence. Its leak site listed over 100 new victims during the June 2026 spike.

JUNE 2026 RESURGENCE

+500%

Month-over-month activity rebound

POST-CRONOS TRAJECTORY



The vacuum created by Cronos accelerated rival growth. RansomHub emerged as the primary beneficiary, absorbing large numbers of former affiliates and ascending to become one of the most active groups globally; Qilin and Akira also expanded significantly.

OUTLOOK — DIMINISHED BUT PERSISTENT

Cronos dismantled LockBit's elite status. Researchers broadly agree the group can continue to operate technically and ship improved variants, but is unlikely to reclaim its former monopoly — now facing sustained competition from operations it helped create through affiliate migration.

SECTION 13

Recommendations

Prioritised by expected reduction in exposure to LockBit and its successor operations.

P1

Harden and monitor virtualisation infrastructure

LockBit 4.0 and 5.0 added ESXi and Linux payloads. Ensure hypervisors are patched, management interfaces are isolated from user VLANs, and EDR or equivalent telemetry covers the hypervisor layer — not only guest operating systems.

P1

Detect exfiltration, not just encryption

Quiet mode is designed to defeat performance-based detection. Prioritise egress anomaly detection, large outbound transfers to file-sharing hosts, and StealBit-style staging behaviour — exfiltration precedes encryption in every double-extortion case.

P2

Reduce Active Directory blast radius

StealBit specifically targeted AD environments. Enforce tiered administration, remove standing privilege, monitor for anomalous replication and Group Policy changes, and hold offline backups of directory state.

P2

Extend ransomware assurance to third parties

TSMC was extorted through supplier Kinmax. Map suppliers holding sensitive data, contract for breach notification timelines, and rehearse a supplier-origin extortion scenario.

P2

Track tradecraft, not brands

Former LockBit affiliates now operate under RansomHub, Qilin, Akira, Medusa and Cloak. Detection content and threat models should key on shared initial-access and lateral-movement behaviour rather than family names.

P3

Check for a free decryptor before considering payment

Over 7,000 keys recovered in Cronos remain available through law enforcement and No More Ransom. Contact the NCA, FBI or a national CERT before any payment decision — and record the decision rationale for regulators.

Assumption — the organisation already maintains tested, offline, immutable backups and enforced multi-factor authentication on all external access. If either is absent, both precede every item above.

SECTION 14

Sources and methodology

Open-source reporting, law enforcement disclosures and dark web collection.

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therecord.media

 Method

Findings were assembled from government and law enforcement primary disclosures, vendor threat research, and collection from Russian-language criminal forums. Claims originating from the group itself are labelled as such and treated as self-reported.

 Limitations

Leak-site victim counts overstate true impact — LockBit has recycled prior victims to simulate activity. Unpaid and unreported incidents are absent from all figures. Sector rankings other than manufacturing are relative, not measured.

CONFIDENCE SCALE

- HIGH

Corroborated by two or more reliable primary sources; little scope for alternative explanation.
- MOD

Credibly sourced but partially uncorroborated, or dependent on self-reported criminal claims.
- LOW

Single-source or inferential; plausible alternative explanations remain open.

End of report · version 1.0

TLP:WHITE — may be shared without restriction. Prepared by Rakesh R, August 2026.